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Mexican parent's undocumented status and the educational attainment of the children left behind

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ABSTRACT

Research shows that having undocumented parents lowers the educational attainment of children that grew up in the United States, but we know less about how it affects the education of children left behind in their origin countries. We use fixed effects models and data from the Mexican Migration Project to examine this relationship. We find that having both parents documented increases the educational attainment of children left behind by over two years in comparison to similar children with mixed-status, undocumented, and nonimmigrant parents. The effect is especially robust for boys that migrate as teenagers. These findings reveal that US immigration laws that define most Mexican immigrants as undocumented have had a devastating effect on the education of Mexican children left behind.

As of 2016, an estimated 11.3 million undocumented immigrants lived in the United States (Krogstad et al., 2017). Mexican immigrants are particularly likely to have an immigration status as undocumented because almost half of all Mexican immigrants are undocumented, and more than half of undocumented immigrants are Mexican (Lopez et al., 2015).

Being undocumented reduces the life chances of immigrants and their family members in numerous ways (Menjívar and Kanstroom, 2014). In this project, we focus on the relationship between Mexican parent's immigration status and the educational attainment of the children they leave behind. Research on immigrant incorporation among children raised in the United States shows that those with undocumented parents attain less education or have slower cognitive development than those with documented parents (Abrego, 2006; Bean et al., 2011; Enriquez, 2011; Landale et al., 2016; Suárez-Orozco et al., 2011; Yoshikawa, 2011; Greenman and Hall, 2013).

However, many Mexican parents leave some or all of their children in Mexico because the trip is expensive and dangerous for undocumented children (Dreby, 2010; Martínez et al., 2013; Nobles, 2013). Quantitative research on the education of children left behind focusses on the effects of parent's migration (Antman, 2012; Lara, 2015; Kandel and Massey, 2002), rather than their immigration status. This is surprising because in-depth interviews with family members left behind in Mexico and other countries indicates that when parents are undocumented, the families incur additional economic hardship, receive less economic support, and the relationships between parents and children are strained (Menjívar, 2012; Dreby, 2010; Abrego, 2014).

To date, no one has carefully analyzed the relationship between parent's immigration status and the education of the children left behind with a representative sample of children while controlling for other factors. Doing so is important because researching immigration status solely within an immigrant incorporation perspective makes the global consequences of restrictive immigration

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legislation invisible. It is possible that restrictive immigration laws in rich countries reduce the educational outcomes of the children left behind. If so, then US laws are partially responsible for low levels of educational attainment in Mexico and for the inability of Mexican immigrants to translate their sacrifices into greater educational opportunities for their children.

To understand these binational processes, we ask 1) does Mexican parent's immigration status affect the educational attainment of the children they left behind? 2) Do children left behind benefit as much from having mixed-status parents (where only one parent is documented) as children with all of their parents documented? And 3) does the effect of parent's immigration status vary by children's sex or whether the children migrate as teenagers?

To answer our questions, we develop hypotheses from three theories of educational attainment: the status attainment model, the theory of social capital, and neoclassical economics. We use a sample of 37,416 children in the Mexican Migration Project (MMP154) to regress children's years of education onto parent's immigration status with controls for family and child differences and fixed effects for communities and years. We also test the robustness of our findings to the presence of omitted variable bias (Frank, 2000). The results and discussion follow.

1. Background

We begin by defining our terms. Children left behind include those that remain in Mexico up to age 12 even though one or more of their parents has migrated to the United States. We use age 12 because this is when many children in Mexico begin dropping out of school (Kandel and Massey, 2002). Undocumented parents are those that enter the United States without inspection or that violate the terms of their visa. Documented parents include legal permanent residents (i.e., green card holders) and naturalized citizens. Nonimmigrant parents are those that live in Mexico and have not migrated by age 12 of the child. This study includes nonimmigrants to see if any type of parental migration is different than parents staying put.

Latinx critical race scholars argue that US immigration laws are anti-Mexican and produce many undocumented Mexican immigrants (De Genova, 2014; Johnson and Trujillo, 2011). This legal construction of Mexican immigrants as undocumented creates social, economic, and political barriers for their social mobility and opportunities in life. US laws grant undocumented immigrants fewer rights and protections and impose harsher punishments on them than on documented immigrants (Johnson and Trujillo, 2011).[1] Although Mexicans primarily migrate for work, undocumented immigrants cannot lawfully work for wages, and they are deportable “aliens” (De Genova, 2014). They are particularly unlikely to use formal bureaucracies and organizations, including public ones, because they do not qualify, lack identification, lack information, or fear detection (Menjívar and Kanstroom, 2014).

Some researchers consider undocumented Mexican labor to be a form of “imported colonialism” that benefits the US state, employers, and consumers more than it does Mexicans and Mexican immigrants (Burawoy, 1976; De Genova, 2014; Ngai, 2004). A finding that the children of documented parents attain more education than similar children of undocumented parents is consistent with this view because it suggests that US immigration laws limit the ability of undocumented parents to translate their sacrifices into educational opportunities for their children.

2. Parental-immigration status and the education of children left behind

We use three theories of educational attainment to understand our focal relationship: the status attainment model, the theory of social capital, and neoclassical economics. According to the status attainment model, children's educational attainment rises with parent's education, parent's occupational prestige, and family income (Haller and Portes, 1973). Documented immigrants and nonimmigrants have more education than undocumented immigrants (Malone, 2004), but by US standards, all of them have little education. These small educational differences produce small differences in occupational prestige between nonimmigrants, documented immigrants and undocumented immigrants. We assume that these small differences among parents result from premigration factors and control for them when estimating the effects of parental immigration status.

Mexican immigrants (undocumented or not) in the United States average higher wages than nonimmigrants in Mexico (Massey et al., 2002). The higher wages of immigrants can potentially benefit the children left behind through remittances. However, the cost of living is also higher in the United States, and undocumented Mexicans usually go into debt to finance their migration. Abrego's (2014) study of family members left behind indicates that remittances from undocumented immigrants are usually only enough to pay off debts and purchase necessities like food and clothes. While the goal of remittances may be to help children in school, it is unclear whether or not they do.

Documented Mexican immigrants are likely to remit more money than their undocumented counterparts. Among immigrants, citizens and those with higher incomes provide relatively more remittances (Waldinger, 2008). Documented Mexican immigrants have slightly higher wages than undocumented Mexican immigrants (Hall et al., 2010). They can also qualify for unemployment insurance and other benefits (Hurst and Chiswick, 2000), at least prior to legal changes in 1996 (Menjívar and Kanstroom, 2014). Finally, migrating to the United States is also more expensive for undocumented than documented immigrants because the former often pay high fees to *coyotes* (border crossing guides). Hence, documented parents should send larger remittances than undocumented parents to their left behind children.

Theories of social capital stress the quantity and quality of intergenerational contact as factors promoting educational attainment

[1] Naturalized citizenship provides more rights and protections and reduces the chances of deportation in comparison to legal permanent residency (Menjívar and Kanstroom, 2014). We do not explore these differences in this paper because our data has very few naturalized citizens.

(Coleman, 1988). Parent-child relationships are particularly important. For example, children in the United States with absent parents, overworked parents, and many siblings show slower cognitive development, more behavioral problems, and higher high school dropout rates (Parcel and Menaghan, 1994; Coleman, 1988).

Children left behind by one and especially two immigrant parents lose social capital from periods of separation, regardless of the parent's status. Immigrant parents reduce the negative effects of international separation by regular long-distance communication, which they do more often than parents who are absent from marital dissolution (Flores-Yeffal, 2013; Nobles, 2011, 2013). Immigrant parents also send their children gifts to demonstrate their love (Dreby, 2010). Despite such attempts, Children often view parental immigration as abandonment and experience anxiety and depression, reducing educational outcomes (Abrego, 2014; Dreby, 2010). In addition, social capital in migrant families can reduce children's education if it leads children to migrate as teenagers (Kandel and Massey, 2002; Lara, 2015), as we explain below.

Compared to undocumented immigrants, documented immigrants take trips with a longer duration and the parents are more likely to live together in the United States (Massey et al., 2002). For the children left behind, these differences suggest that having documented parents will reduce parent-child contact and perhaps social capital. However, the duration of trips by documented and undocumented Mexican immigrants have become more similar since the late-1990s (Massey et al., 2016). In addition, documented immigrants visit Mexico more often for events such as *fiestas patronales*, holidays, and birthdays because they can return to the United States at official crossing points safely and without hiring *coyotes* (Abrego, 2014; Waldinger, 2008). Undocumented immigrants do not make frequent trips to visit their children in Mexico because of the danger and cost of crossing the border back to the United States.

In addition, having an undocumented parent can cause fear, anxiety and uncertainty in children's lives because their parent could be hurt or die crossing the border, be victim of a crime, fail to find work, be unable to send regular remittances or to delay their return (Abrego, 2014; Dreby, 2010; Flores-Yeffal, 2013). Having undocumented parents, relative to documented ones, also makes the children's future uncertain. Undocumented parents cannot sponsor their children to get a green card, so the children do not know if, when or how they will migrate to the United States and join their parent(s). Children with documented parents have less uncertainty because their parents often plan to bring them to the United States legally (Abrego, 2014). For these reasons, having an undocumented parent is likely to strain parent-child relationships and reduce social capital.

In the neoclassical economic model (e.g., Lara, 2015; McKenzie and Rapaport, 2011), children determine how much time and effort to invest in education by assessing its potential benefits in comparison to its costs. Economists maintain that early in the teenage years, many Mexican teenagers begin to see emigration to the United States for work as more beneficial than staying in school, which delays the earning of US wages. Perhaps more importantly, rewards to additional schooling for undocumented immigrants are low in the US labor market (Hall et al., 2010). The main costs of migrating are fees to *coyotes* and the danger and uncertainty of crossing the border and finding work. These costs can be reduced by quality information on how to cross and where to find work, so social ties to experienced migrants, particularly to migrant parents, can tip the calculus in favor of migration rather than school (Kandel and Massey, 2002; Lara, 2015). Some researchers suggest that there is a net negative effect of Mexican parent's emigration on children's education because of this causal pathway (Lara, 2015).

However, the application of the neoclassical economic model described above assumes that the immigrant parents are undocumented. How would the cost-benefit analyses change if they are documented? The main difference is that documented children can realistically *expect* to become documented because their parents can sponsor them. While this process can take years, especially if the parents are only legal permanent residents rather than naturalized citizens (Gubernskaya and Dreby, 2017), having a documented status will increase the child's economic returns on their education and provide a powerful incentive to stay in school (Gonzalez, 2011; Hall et al., 2010), particularly for boys, as we explain below. For example, documented children with technical or professional degrees can legally take jobs that require these qualifications in the United States. Although transferring degrees from Mexico may require additional training, these jobs are nearly impossible to obtain without documents.

In sum, the status attainment and neoclassical economic model predict that children left behind by documented parents will attain more education than children with undocumented or nonimmigrant parents. The social capital theory suggests that children with nonimmigrant parents will have more social capital than children with documented and especially undocumented parents. Taken together, the theories suggest:

Hypothesis 1. In comparison to similar children with nonimmigrant parents, those with documented parents will attain more years of education and those with undocumented parents will attain fewer years of education.

An additional consideration is the difference between having both parents documented versus having mixed-status parents. Largely for legal reasons, children left behind are more likely to have mixed-status parents—where one of two parents are documented—than both parents documented (Gubernskaya and Dreby, 2017). Previous research finds that parent's undocumented status impacts and limits all the choices and opportunities available to families (Yoshikawa, 2011). For example, Abrego (2014) finds that it, "… trumps other benefits, no matter how many years of education they have, how many people they know, or how long people have lived in the United States (72)." For example, having an undocumented parent will cause fear and anxiety even if the other parent is documented. Thus, we arrive at,

Hypothesis 2. Children left behind in Mexico with both parents documented will attain more education than similar children with mixed-status parents.

The consequences of parent's immigration status may differ by whether or not the children migrate as teenagers and by the child's sex. Many Mexican teenagers, especially boys, drop out of school and migrate to the United States without documents (Kandel and

Massey, 2002; Oropesa and Landale, 2009). Although public schools in the United States will admit them, they often do not enroll. They are likely to live within what Flores-Yeffal (2013) calls Migration-Trust Networks (MTNs). These are self-segregated daughter communities of undocumented immigrants that provide social support and information about how to manage their lives in the shadows. These MTNs channel undocumented teenagers into the large underground labor market rather than into schools (Bauder, 1998; Garcia, 2005; Tilly, 2007). If teenage immigrants with documented parents are less likely to be in MTNs and to enroll in US schools, the teenage immigrants are likely to attain much higher levels of education than their counterparts with undocumented parents. Teenage immigrants may also benefit more than their nonimmigrant peers from having documented parents because normal levels of educational attainment are much higher in the United States than in Mexico. Hence, we expect that:

Hypothesis 3. Teenage immigrants benefit more from having documented parents than children that never migrate.

In Mexico, girls attain slightly more years of education than males, but this difference is reversed in families and communities with fewer resources (Post, 2002). Poor communities and poor families are associated with girls performing relatively more domestic labor and attending school less. While poverty sometimes leads boys to work at a young age, families invest relatively more in the education of boys than in girls as family resources diminish, creating a male advantage in education. Improvements in family resources help girls close the gap. The gendered nature of Mexican migration, which is dominated by men, may also free left-behind mothers to treat girls more equally; similarly, boy's education may suffer from a lack of male role models in migrant sending communities (Antman, 2012; Kandel and Kao, 2001). Thus, we expect girls in Mexico to be affected more by parent's immigration status than boys. This leads to,

Hypothesis 4. Girls that never migrate will benefit more from having documented parents than boys that never migrate.

For boys and girls that migrate as teenagers, the effect of having documented parents is likely to be greater for boys than girls. According to the neoclassical economic perspective, the main incentive for staying in school among teenage immigrants is the high returns on education if they are documented. However, this explanation applies more to teenage immigrant boys than girls because a larger share of Mexican boys aspire to work in the United States (Kandel and Kao, 2000; Kandel and Massey, 2002; Parreñas, 2005; París Pombo, 2010). Despite the gradual increase of women participating in international migration, the "traditional explanations for men's migration do not apply to women (Donato et al., 2006:12)." Mexican girls encounter societal and familial norms against pursuing college and employment after marriage (Kandel and Kao, 2001). In addition, documented status increases the returns to education more for boys than girls (Hall et al., 2010). According to the neoclassical economic model, these higher returns to wages will give male teenage immigrants with documented parents more incentives to stay in school than their female counterparts (Hall et al., 2010). This may be because many Mexican female migrants perform domestic labor that requires little education (Hondagneu-Sotelo, 2011). Based on this evidence, we expect:

Hypothesis 5. Among Mexican teenage immigrants, boys will benefit more than girls from having documented parents.

We now explain how we test these hypotheses.

3. Methods

Data for this study come from the Mexican Migration Project (MMP154). These data derive from ethnosurveys collected from household heads living in Mexico and the United States between 1987 and 2015. Household heads were surveyed one time but the survey contains detailed retrospective information. The Mexican households are randomly selected from 154 Mexican communities, roughly five communities per year. Douglas Massey and Jorge Duran designed the MMP to reduce the undercount of immigrants. They and their team interview Mexican household heads during the winter months when more immigrants return for the holidays; ask household heads about their entire migration history; about the first and last trip of all the other members of the household; and about any households from their community that have migrated to the United States. Once identified, they contact those households and interview them in the United States. Finally, they design weights to make the sample representative of people from the 154 communities in the year of the survey (Massey and Zenteno, 2000; Massey and Capoferro, 2004), which we use in all analyses. More detailed information about the Mexican Migration Project (MMP) databases and design methods is also available online (http://mmp.opr.princeton.edu/).

We use the person file, which contains information on each household member, to construct a data set of the "children" of the household head and predict their highest year of education completed. We attach data from other files as needed. Our analytic sample excludes children less than 22 years of age at the time of the survey to ensure that most of the children are done with school.[2] We also exclude children if their parents are not born in Mexico or if their parents migrated to a non-US country. Children born in the United States or that migrated to it by age 12 are also excluded because they were not left behind. Finally, we exclude children born before 1960. While going back this far makes the results of our study less applicable to the present than we would prefer, doing so allows us to include sample members that bookend the Immigration Reform and Control Act (IRCA), passed in 1986. This piece of legislation is important for our study because it resulted in over two million Mexican immigrants receiving amnesty and becoming documented

[2] We also repeated our analyses with alternative sample criteria. These include limiting it to children that are at least 20 years of age, to only children with at least one immigrant parent, and to children that completed at least six years of education (so they are in school at age 12). These models did not alter the substantive findings about the effects of documented parents relative to mixed status ones, undocumented one, and (if included) nonimmigrant ones.

(Massey et al., 2002). This is the only program since the 1960s that provided a substantial number of Mexicans a path toward documented status.

3.1. Measurement

The dependent variable is children's years of education. We measure parental immigration and immigration status as of when the child is age twelve, which we refer to as time t. For example, parents are considered documented if they entered or lived in the United States with documents by time t. We chose age 12 because the theories of status attainment and social capital point to family dynamics that influence educational achievement and development during early as well as late childhood. Current research also shows that most of the inequality in children's educational achievement is formed by age 12 if not younger (e.g., see Alexander et al., 2007). In Mexico, dropout rates rise after primary school, so independent variables measured at time t capture information about children and their circumstances while most of the children are still in school (see note 2).

Parents are considered immigrants if their first or last trip occured before time t and the duration is at least four months. Parents are coded as documented if they entered the United States as a legal resident, citizen, Silva letter holder, or refugee or if they received a green card, legal permanent residency, or citizenship. Undocumented immigrants are those that entered the United States without documents or that entered the United States on a tourist visa and stayed longer than three months or got a job. Some Mexican parents are better classified as temporary migrants because they entered as Braceros, H2A visa holders, or temporary workers. Rather than omit children with these parents, we create a dummy variable for them. In the case that parent's classification differs on their first and last trips (which primarily occurred when the first trip's duration was less than four months), we used the classification from the last trip that occured before time t. The inclusion of information from the last trip only reclassified 0.7 percent of parents. The rest of the parents are nonimmigrants.

Parent's immigration status can be operationalized in multiple ways because there are two parents, two gender roles and four statuses. In the models we present, we use an operationalization that emphasizes differences in immigration status because that is the focal variable. We create dummy variables for: both parents documented, mixed-status parents (i.e., with one of two parents documented), undocumented parents, temporary parents, and nonimmigrant parents. The definition of each dummy variable is shown in Table 1. The immigration status of the two parents always match in the dummy variables both parents documented and nonimmigrant parents. The immigration status of the two parents do not necessarily match in the other dummy variables. However, we maximized our information on documentation by coding all families with one documented parent as mixed status. Of the rest, we maximized our information on undocumented status by coding all of the rest with at least one undocumented parent as undocumented. After those, we did the same thing for temporary immigrants. If there is only one parent, they are classified according to the first parent listed in the table. If there is only one parent and they are documented, they are classified in “both parents documented.” Since having a single parent is usually detrimental, this makes the test for “both parents documented” more conservative.

We also analyzed other ways of operationalizing parent's immigration status, including ones that have (1) dummy variables that are based on both status and the number of parents that migrate; (2) categories that included the sex of the parent (e.g., a documented father and an undocumented mother); and (3) categories based on the largest frequencies (e.g., an undocumented father migrating without the mother). We do not show the results from these other methods because they produce substantively identical results: children with both parents documented earn more years of education than children with any other type of parental immigration status regardless of how we define the other categories, which is consistent with the models presented below.

Teenage immigrants are those that enter the United States for the first time during the ages of 12–19 and stay for at least three months on either their first or last trip. We use a three-month cutoff to eliminate trips done solely for tourism. When we analyze the entire sample, including a dummy variable for teenage immigrants will capture some of the effects of parental immigration status. When we run models conditional on teenage migration, we also control for the age of their first US trip because those that migrate at a younger age may be more likely to enroll in US schools.

We control for predictors of educational attainment. Community differences in Mexico are especially important to consider because undocumented immigrants are likely to originate from rural communities (which sometimes lack middle schools and high schools) with few good jobs, low levels of educational attainment, and high teenage migration rates (Kandel and Massey, 2002; Massey and Espinosa, 1997; Santibañez et al., 2005). Rather than construct variables to describe community factors associated with more or less education, we used fixed effects by including 153 dummy variables for the 154 different communities. The dummy variables capture the net effect of all factors in each community. Thus, they capture the effects of such things as whether or not the community has a high school, the local unemployment rate, the emigration rate, and other variation across communities.

Table 1
Operational definitions of parent's immigration status.

Variable	First parent	Second parent
Both parents documented	Documented	Documented
Mixed-status parents	Documented	Undocumented, temporary, or nonimmigrant
Undocumented parents	Undocumented	Undocumented, temporary or nonimmigrant
Temporary parents	Temporary	Temporary or nonimmigrant
Nonimmigrant parents	Nonimmigrant	Nonimmigrant

As per the status attainment model, we control for parent's years of education and occupation. If we have information on both parent's years of education, we average their two scores. If we have information on only one parent, we use theirs. We use dummy variables for parent's occupations—which are reported separately for mothers and fathers at the time of the survey—in these categories: out of the labor force, unskilled occupations other than farm labor, skilled occupations, professionals and managers, and farm laborers.

The MMP does not contain a measure of household income. However, we have multiple measures of economic resources. One is the head's capital assets. It equals one if by time t the household head owns land and a business, 0.5 if they own one of these, and zero otherwise. Another measure of economic resources is an index of household amenities that equals the proportion of 12 amenities contained in the household. The amenities range from running water and electricity to refrigerators and computers. We use this measure because household possessions are used by organizations like the National Center for Education Statistics to construct measures of socioeconomic status to predict educational outcomes. Another variable correlated with income is parent's age during the year the child is born because incomes tend to rise with age.

Unfortunately, the MMP does not have an adequate measure of remittances from parents. The survey only asks about remittances at the time of the survey and does not ask if they are from parents. A fair number of households with nonimmigrant parents receive remittances. This means that the effect of remittances is likely to be included in the dummy variables for parental immigration status, the variables about economic resources measured at the time of the survey (i.e., household amenities),[3] and the error term.

The social capital perspective suggests that more interaction between parents and children will improve educational attainment. Thus, we include dummy variables to indicate children that had one parent between birth and time t. We also control for whether or not the child is the oldest and the child's birth order because contact with parents declines as the number of children rises.

The neoclassical economic model suggests that factors that decrease the costs of migration encourage children to drop out of school. For this reason, we add controls for children with social ties to family members with migration experience. To measure family's migration experience beyond that of the parents, we use dummy variables to indicate whether a grandparent, aunt, or uncle of the child made a US trip by time t. We also account for time trends with fixed effects by including 35 dummy variables for year of birth (which ranges from 1960 to 1995) as well as with a dummy variable indicating children who turned 12 after 1996, the year that two anti-immigrant laws were enacted (Menjívar and Kanstroom, 2014).

Unfortunately, we are unable to measure mediating variables suggested by our theories. In addition to lacking a measure of remittances, we would also like to know which children expect to become documented, but this is also not in the survey. We can measure which children are documented by time t, but this is only 45 of the 37,416 children. Many of the children in our sample receive documents at a later age. As mentioned earlier, we can measure an aspect of social capital by identifying whether or not children have zero, one or two immigrant parents (it has no discernible effect), but we cannot measure the qualities of parent-child relationships. Finally, we cannot measure whether or not teenage immigrants work in the United States. While there are measures of their occupation that can distinguish students from workers, they are not time specific and some teenage immigrants that initially were students may be listed as workers. Measures for these variables would help us learn more about how parent's immigration status affects children.

3.2. Analysis

We predict children's years of education in weighted least-squares (WLS) regression models using fixed effects for communities and children's years of birth. We use the weight developed by the MMP staff to make the results generalizable to residents of the 154 communities in the year surveyed. We adjust standard errors for the clustering of children within households. Analyses are estimated in the SAS procedure surveyreg (Allison, 2005).

The models we present use multiple (6) imputations for cases with missing values calculated in the SAS procedure mi (Allison, 2002). We use SAS's mianalyze to combine the results from the six imputations. All but one of the variables measuring parent's immigration status have missing information for about 20 percent of the cases. Missing values are prevalent for these variables because there is often missing information on the migration history of the spouse. The one that differs is, “both parents documented,” which is central to the analyses. It is missing in less than one percent of the cases because it can be coded zero if the household head is not documented. The rest of the variables are missing in less than 1.5 percent of cases. We also compared the results obtained by combining them across imputations (which is what we present in the paper) to those obtained from each imputation and from models estimated with listwise deletion. Our substantive findings are consistent across these models, adding confidence in our results.

The primary threat to producing unbiased estimates for the coefficients for parent's immigration status is omitted variable bias. Omitted variable bias will occur if there is an unobserved confounding variable (cv) that is exogenous and that has a high partial correlation with parent's immigration status (x) and children's years of education (y). By partial correlation, we mean net of all of the other variables in the model. If the partial correlations (r) are high enough, including the confounding variable in the model can change a significant coefficient for x to not significant and alter the results of the study. To formally gauge the sensitivity of the significant coefficients about parent's immigration status to the influence of an omitted confounder, we calculated the Impact Threshold for Confounding Variables (Frank, 2000; Crosnoe, 2009). The ITCV is interpreted as the minimum value that the product of

[3] We considered using our measure of household amenities as a mediating variable that would capture the economic benefits of immigration, but found that most of the variation in it is exogenous to parental migration. Removing the variable from the models increases the coefficients for the different measures of parental status by one or two tenths but does not alter the substantive findings.

Table 2
Descriptive statistics for the whole sample and for five groups of children.

	Total sample		APD	BDP	MSP	UP	NIP
	Mean	StD	Means				
Years of education	9.08	10.55	10.25	11.84	9.73	8.58	9.22
Any parent documented	0.02		1	1	1	0	0
Both parents documented	0.01		0.25	1	0	0	0
Mixed-status parents	0.02		0.75	0	1	0	0
Undocumented parents	0.18		0	0	0	1	0
Temporary immigrant parents	0.08		0	0	0	0	0
Nonimmigrant parents	0.72		0	0	0	0	1
Immigrant grandparent	0.05		0.24	0.40	0.19	0.09	0.03
Immigrant uncle or aunt	0.19		0.56	0.77	0.50	0.36	0.11
Parent's years of education	4.19	8.76	5.32	5.47	5.27	3.59	4.44
Parent's age year born	28.9	17.5	27.0	26.6	27.2	29.1	28.6
One parent	0.02		0.03	0.03	0.04	0.03	0.02
Oldest child	0.22		0.24	0.20	0.26	0.19	0.23
Child's birth order	3.78	6.74	3.29	3.16	3.34	4.07	3.62
Female child	0.49		0.45	0.40	0.47	0.50	0.49
Household head's capital	0.15	0.67	0.16	0.19	0.16	0.14	0.15
Post 1996	0.07		0.04	0.01	0.05	0.07	0.08
Household amenities	0.79	0.45	0.89	0.91	0.89	0.81	0.78
Father is a farm laborer	0.44		0.27	0.20	0.29	0.49	0.43
Year born	1970.9	19.3	1969.7	1969.5	1969.7	1970.5	1971.4
Teenage immigrant child	0.08		0.26	0.34	0.23	0.14	0.05
N	37,416		686	118	568	6514	27,192

Key: StD = standard deviation. APD = any parent documented; BPD = both parents documented; MSP = mixed-status parents; UP = undocumented parents; NIP = nonimmigrant parents. Children with temporary immigrant parents are not shown separately.

these two partial correlations ($r_{x,cv} * r_{cv,y}$) can take for the coefficient of x to become not significant. The ITCV depends on the sample size (n), the t-cutoff value (i.e., 1.65 on a one-tailed test), the number of parameters in the model (q), and the partial correlation between x and y ($r_{x,y}$). It equals:

$$\frac{r_{x,y} - r^{\#}_{xy}}{1 - r^{\#}_{x,y}}$$

where

$$r^{\#}_{x,y} = \frac{t}{\sqrt{(n - q - 1) + t^2}}$$

The larger the ITCV, the less likely it is that an omitted confounding variable (or a set of them) can be identified that would change the results of the study.

4. Results

Table 2 shows the descriptive statistics for the entire sample of children and by parent's immigration status. As seen there, all the children together average 9.08 years of education. Two and 18 percent of the children have been left behind by at least one documented and undocumented parent, respectively. Most of the children have nonimmigrant parents (72 percent). Children's years of education varies with their parent's immigration status in the ways we expect based on previous literature. Children with any parent documented (APD) average 10.25 years of education. However, those that have both parents documented (BPD) attain more years of education (11.84 years) than the ones with mixed-status parents (MSP) (9.73 years). The children with undocumented parents (UP) attain just 8.58 years, which is even lower than those with nonimmigrant parents (NIP) (9.22).

Background differences are important to control. For example, parental education averages between 5.3 and 5.5 years in the categories that include a documented parent. Undocumented parents average fewer years of education (3.6) than all other parents, including nonimmigrant parents (4.4). According to the neoclassical economic perspective, teenage migration may have negative consequences for children's education. The table shows that about 14 percent of children with undocumented parents migrate as teenagers, which is much higher than for children with nonimmigrant parents (5 percent). But children with both parents documented are particularly likely to migrate as teenagers (34 percent).

4.1. Weighted-least-squares regression models

Table 3 show the results from the WLS models for the whole sample predicting children's years of education with parent's immigration status and control variables. We begin by briefly discussing the control variables, but we limit our discussion of them to

Table 3
Coefficients from weighted least squares regression of selected variables onto the years of education of children left behind by Mexican immigrant parents (N = 37,416).

	1		2		3		4	
	b	s.e.	*b*	s.e.	*b*	s.e.	*b*	s.e.
Parent's immigration status								
Any parent documented	0.52	0.34						
Both parents documented			2.27	0.76**	2.42	0.77**	2.07	1.02*
Mixed-status parents			−0.02	0.29[a]	0.10	0.30[a]	0.05	0.34
Undocumented parents	−0.08	0.10	−0.08	0.09[a]	−0.06	0.09[a]	−0.01	0.10
Temporary immigrant parents	0.11	0.15	0.12	0.15[a]	0.12	0.15[a]	0.17	0.15
Nonimmigrant parents (ref.)								
Both docum. * teen migrant							0.99	1.48
Mix-stat * teen migrant							0.17	0.47
Undoc.* teen migrant							−0.33	0.22
Temp. * teen migrant							−0.23	0.30
Teenage immigrant					−0.95	0.10***	−0.88	0.11***
Control variables								
Immigrant grandparent	0.36	0.21	0.32	0.19	0.39	0.19	0.39	0.19*
Immigrant uncle or aunt	0.14	0.10	0.12	0.10	0.14	0.10	0.14	0.10
Parent's years of education	0.41	0.01***	0.41	0.01***	0.41	0.01***	0.41	0.01***
Parent's age (year child born)	0.06	0.01***	0.06	0.01***	0.06	0.01***	0.06	0.01***
One parent family	0.28	0.25	0.28	0.25	0.30	0.25	0.29	0.25
Oldest child	0.48	0.06***	0.48	0.06***	0.47	0.06***	0.48	0.06***
Child's birth order	−0.05	0.02**	−0.05	0.02**	−0.05	0.02**	−0.05	0.02**
Female child	0.11	0.05*	0.11	0.05*	0.04	0.05	0.04	0.05
Household head's assets	0.86	0.15***	0.85	0.15***	0.87	0.15***	0.86	0.15***
Post 1996	0.20	0.39	0.18	0.39	0.15	0.39	0.14	0.39
Household amenities	6.47	0.26***	6.46	0.26***	6.57	0.26***	6.56	0.26***
intercept	−0.25	0.44	−0.22	0.44	−0.17	0.44	−0.18	0.44
Includes occupation dummies	yes		yes		yes		yes	
Includes year born dummies	yes		yes		yes		yes	
Includes community dummies	yes		yes		yes		yes	
Adjusted R-squared	0.38		0.38		0.39		0.39	

Notes: *$p < .05$, **$p < .01$, ***$p < .001$, Two-tailed tests.
[a] Coefficient significantly different from coefficient for "Both parents documented" at $p < .05$ on a two tailed test.

those in Table 3 since they are not the main focus. As foreseen by the status attainment model, parent's education, household amenities, capital assets, and parent's age when the child is born are all positively associated with educational attainment. Although the coefficients for parent's occupations are not shown, they indicate that children with fathers in professional and managerial occupations, skilled occupations, and unskilled occupations other than farm labor all attain slightly more education than children with parents who are farm laborers.

In contrast, children with mothers that do not work attain more education than children with mothers in any occupational category, a finding that is more consistent with social capital theory than with the status attainment model. Also consistent with the theory of social capital, we find that the oldest child attains more education than other children and that as the child's birth order increases, their level of attainment declines. However, we find no effect from having one rather than two parents other things being equal. The neoclassical economic perspective suggests that children with social ties to immigrants are more likely to drop out of school to migrate. However, we do not find support for this perspective, as seen by the nonsignificant coefficients for immigrant grandparents and immigrant uncles/aunts. Model 1 also show that females attain 0.11 more years of education than males other things being equal. However, when the dummy variable for teenage immigrants is added in Model 3, the coefficient for female becomes nonsignificant, suggesting that the higher rates of teenage migration among boys are partially responsible for the female advantage in educational attainment.

As seen at the bottom of Table 3, the models also include dummy variables for the communities of origin and year of birth (coefficients not shown). To gauge the importance of the dummy variables, we compared the model fit with and without various sets of control variables. These tests indicated that the dummy variables for community of origin explained the most variation in children's education, supporting other work stressing community differences as determinates of educational outcomes (e.g., Santibañez et al., 2005).

We now discuss the hypothesis tests. Hypothesis one states that children with nonimmigrant parents will attain less education than those with any parent documented and more than those with undocumented parents. This is tested in model one by including dummy variables for parent's immigration status (using nonimmigrant parents as the reference category). As seen in Table 3, the coefficient for any parent documented is not significant, indicating that hypothesis one is not supported. In addition, all of the other coefficients for parent's immigration status are close to zero and about the same size as their standard errors.

Hypothesis two states that having both parents documented will result in more years of education for children than having mixed-status parents. As seen in Model 2, the coefficient for both parents documented is positive and indicates that children with these

Table 4
Coefficients from weighted least squares regression of selected variables onto nonmigrant children's and teenage immigrant's years of education.

Variable	Nonimmigrant children				Teenage immigrants			
	1		2		3		4	
	b	s.e.	*b*	s.e.	*b*	s.e.	*b*	s.e.
Parent(s) immigration status								
Both parents documented	2.11	0.98*	1.91	0.86*	3.85	1.05***	4.86	1.11***
Mixed-status parents	0.02	0.35[a]	0.03	0.41	0.49	0.42[a]	0.39	0.43
Undocumented parents	−0.01	0.10[a]	0.00	0.13	−0.15	0.24[a]	0.00	0.25
Temporary immigrant parents	0.17	0.16[a]	0.26	0.20	0.17	0.28[a]	0.32	0.31
Nonimmigrant parents (reference)								
Both parents documented * female			0.47	0.96			−3.68	1.02***
Mixed-status parents * female			−0.04	0.38			0.07	0.71
Undocumented parents * female			−0.04	0.18			−0.76	0.42
Temp immigrant parents * female			−0.23	0.23			−0.37	0.62
Control Variables								
Age at first US Trip					−0.03	0.04	−0.03	0.04
Immigrant grandparent	0.41	0.22	0.41	0.22	0.52	0.27	0.49	0.27
Immigrant uncle or aunt	0.16	0.11	0.16	0.11	0.08	0.20	0.06	0.20
Parent's years of education	0.41	0.01***	0.41	0.01***	0.32	0.03***	0.32	0.03***
Parent's age year child born	0.06	0.01***	0.06	0.01***	0.05	0.02**	0.05	0.02**
One parent family	0.24	0.27	0.23	0.27	1.09	0.52*	1.06	0.53*
Female child	0.05	0.06	0.05	0.06	0.32	0.21*	0.65	0.28*
Oldest child	0.47	0.06***	0.47	0.06***	0.56	0.22**	0.55	0.22**
Child's birth order	−0.05	0.02**	−0.05	0.02**	−0.04	0.05	−0.04	0.05
Household head's capital assets	0.86	0.15***	0.86	0.15***	0.79	0.36*	0.82	0.34*
Post 1996	0.12	0.40	0.12	0.40	1.12	0.95	1.11	0.95
Household amenities	6.73	0.27***	6.73	0.27***	3.77	0.57***	3.80	0.57***
Intercept	−0.25	0.45	−0.25	0.45	0.82	1.31	0.85	1.28
Includes occupation dummies	yes		yes		yes		yes	
Includes year of birth dummies	yes		yes		yes		yes	
Includes community dummies	yes		yes		yes		yes	
Adjusted R-squared	0.39		0.39		0.39		0.39	
N	34,484		34,484		2932		2932	

Notes: $*p < .05$, $**p < .01$, $***p < .001$.
[a] Coefficient significantly different from the coefficient for "Both parents documented" at $p < .05$ on a two-tailed test.

parents attain 2.27 more years of education than similar children with nonimmigrant parents. Children with both parents documented attain (2.27 − (−0.02) =) 2.29 more years of education than children with mixed-status parents, which is significant[4] and consistent with the hypothesis. In fact, children with both parents documented attain between 2.15 and 2.35 more years of education than children with parents of any other status.

Model 3 adds a dummy variable to identify those children left behind that go on to migrate as teenagers. Because children are more likely to migrate as teenagers if their parents are immigrants (regardless of parent's status), teenage migration is partially endogenous to the variables about parent's immigration status. The results show that teenage immigrants attain, on average, 0.95 fewer years of education than nonimmigrant children other things equal, highlighting the detriment of teenage migration for children's attainment (e.g., see Kandel and Massey, 2002). However, including the variable only slightly changes the coefficients for parent's immigration status, suggesting its mediation of parent's status is minimal.

Hypothesis three states that the children left behind and migrate as teenagers with both parents documented will attain more education than their counterparts with both parents documented that did not migrate as teenagers because the former are likely to enroll in US schools. This is tested in Model 4 with interaction terms between the variables for parent's immigration status and whether or not the child migrated as a teenager. As seen there, the coefficient for the interaction between both parents documented and teenage immigrant is positive (0.99) but not significant, failing to support the hypothesis. Also notice that teenage immigration does not reduce the educational attainment of children with documented parents (0.99–0.88 = 0.11). The negative effect of teenage migration is erased for children with both parents documented. Later we show that among teenage immigrants, having both parents documented affects boys and girls differently.

Hypothesis four states that nonimmigrant (that is, children that are left behind and do not emigrate as teenagers) girls will benefit more than nonimmigrant boys from having both parents documented. Models 1 and 2 in Table 4 only include nonimmigrant children. The first model shows that nonimmigrant children with both parents documented earn 2.11 more years of education than similar children with nonimmigrant parents and by about the same amount in comparison to children with mixed-status parents and undocumented parents. The second model for nonimmigrant children tests the hypothesis by adding an interaction between the child's

[4] We estimated significance between coefficients by changing the reference category and reestimating the models.

sex and parent's immigration status. As seen in the table, the interaction between both parents documented and female is in the expected direction but not significant (0.47), indicating that the effect of both parents documented is similar for boys and girls. Thus, hypothesis four is not supported.

Models 3 and 4 in Table 4 are conditional upon the children migrating as teenagers. Limiting the sample to teenage immigrants allows us to see if there is any effect of immigration status net of encouraging their children to migrate. As seen in Model 3, the teenage immigrants that have both parents documented earn 3.85 more years of education than children whose parents remain in Mexico (nonimmigrant parents). Those with both parents documented also earn 3.36, 4.00, and 3.68 more years of education than teenage immigrants with mixed-status, undocumented, and temporary parents.

Hypothesis five states that conditional on the child migrating as a teenager, boys will benefit more than girls from having both parents documented. To test this hypothesis, we use the coefficient for the interaction term between both parents documented and female in model 4. As seen in the table, the coefficient is negative and significant, supporting the hypothesis. The magnitude of the main effect of both parents documented indicates that boys that are left behind, migrate as teenagers and have these parents attain (an astounding) 4.86 more years of education than similar boys with nonimmigrant parents. Boys with both parents documented also attain (4.86–0.39 =) 4.47 and 4.86 more years of education than similar boys with mixed-status parents and undocumented parents, respectively. The interaction indicates that females with documented parents attain only (4.86–3.68 =) 1.18 more years of education than similar females with nonimmigrant parents—a difference which is not significant. In other words, having both parents documented does not raise the educational attainment of girls that are left behind and then migrate as teennagers. Moreover, the coefficients also show that among teenage immigrants, girls attain 0.65 more years of education than boys if their parents are not immigrants. But if both parents are documented, teenage immigrant boys attain (−0.65 to 3.68 =) 3.03 more years of education than teenage immigrant girls.

4.2. Impact threshold for confounding variables

We now exam the sensitivity of the significant results to omitted variable bias. Recall that the ITCV is the minimum value that the product of two partial correlations, $r_{x,\ cv} * r_{cv,\ y}$, can take for a coefficient for a focal variable (x) to become nonsignificant when a confounding variable (cv) is added to the model predicting the dependent variable (y). Table 5 shows the estimates for the ITCV for the significant coefficients for both parents documented in the models for 1) all children, 2) all nonimmigrant children, and 3) teenage immigrant boys. We do not calculate the ITCV for teenage immigrant girls because the coefficient is not significant. Impact ks are included in the table because they can help interpret the magnitudes of the ITCVs (Lee and Klugman, 2013). Impact ks are equal to the product of the partial correlations between the independent variables with both parents documented and with years of education ($r_{bpd,\ x} * r_{x,\ y}$).

As seen in Table 5, ITCVs for these three coefficients are 0.044, 0.032, and 0.203, respectively. The square roots of the ITCVs are the approximate thresholds for the partial correlations, which are 0.210, 0.180, and 0.450. This means, for example, that the threshold of 0.044 can be achieved if $r_{x,cv}$ and $r_{cv,y}$ equal 0.210 because 0.210 * 0.210 = 0.044. Of course, the ITVC could also be achieved if one partial correlation was smaller as long as the other was larger. All of the necessary partial correlations are high, but the one for teenage boys is especially so. It is exceedingly unlikely that a variable would have a partial correlation of 0.450 with x and y net of all the variables already in the model. The impact ks are also considerably smaller than the ITCVs, indicating that none of the independent variables in the models come close to reaching the minimal value needed to make the focal relationships not significant. This means that the omitted confounding variable would need to have higher partial correlations than any variable currently in the model and net of the varaibles in the model.

We also investigated numerous variables in the MMP to see if they could reach these thresholds, but we were unsuccessful. We find that the correlates of having both parents documented are different than the ones associated with educational attainment. Educational attainment tends to correlate with variables describing the socioeconomic status of the children's family or community. In contrast, both parents documented has low correlations with variables about socioeconomic status. For example, the partial correlation between both parents documented and parent's years of education is only 0.011. The correlates of both parents documented are primarily about *when the immigrant was in the United States* and not about their family or community characteristics. More than half of the documented parents became so through the Immigration Reform and Control Act of 1986. This one-time program did not require income or education prerequisites, so the people who received papers through it do not have characteristics that would be especially likely to raise the educational attainment of their children. Thus, it is unlikely that omitted variables have high partial correlations with both parents documented and children's years of education.

Table 5
Partial correlations between both parents documented and children's years of education, the Impact Threshold for Confounding Variables and Impact Ks.

Children	Partial r	ITCV	Range of impact ks	SQRT (ITCV)
All children	0.052	0.044	−0.001 - +0.010	0.210
Nonimmigrant children	0.041	0.032	−0.001 - +0.006	0.180
Teenage immigrant boys	0.227	0.203	−0.003 - +0.017	0.450

5. Discussion

This study uses data from the Mexican Migration Project to study the relationship between parent's immigration status and the educational attainment of the children left behind in Mexico, a relationship not previously examined with a large representative data set. We find no significant differences in educational attainment between children with undocumented parents and those with nonimmigrant parents once we account for other factors. This finding allays concerns that Mexican parent's emigration reduces the education of the children left behind. However, we also find that children with both parents documented attain between 2.15 and 2.35 more years of education, on average, than similar children with nonimmigrant parents, undocumented parents, and mixed-status parents. That means that Mexican parent's immigration status influences the educational attainment of the children left behind.

Before discussing the significance of our findings, we place them in the context of the study's limitations. First, generalizations from our results are limited to children born in 1960 or later, with Mexican-born parents, and from the 154 communities sampled in the MMP. Second, our estimates derive from linear regression models using fixed effects for communities and year of birth. This statistical method produces conservative estimates for the effects associated with parent's immigration status, but the results should not be used to draw causal claims with complete confidence. The most likely threat to the accuracy of our estimates is omitted variable bias. We gauge the sensitivity of our results to this threat by estimating the ITCV, which suggests that the effect of having both parents documented relative to having nonimmigrant parents (or other statuses) are robust to omitted variable bias. Nevertheless, replicating this study with other data or other methods would establish greater confidence in our findings. Finally, our understanding of the focal relationship would also be improved by determining which theoretical mechanisms best explain the findings.

5.1. Theoretical implications

Our most important theoretical finding is that the immigration status of Mexican parents affects the educational attainment of the children left behind in Mexico. This finding extends current knowledge about immigration status. While researchers are aware of how immigration status stratifies the foreign born, the bulk of the research on the consequences of immigration status by US sociologists has been conducted within an immigrant incorporation framework. As such, it has ignored the binational and global consequences of restrictive immigration policy. The finding also informs current scholarship on the educational attainment of the children left behind. That research has analyzed the overall effects of immigration status, but it has not analyzed the effects of parents having different statuses, thus ignoring how US immigration laws alter the experiences of the children left behind.

Our findings indicate that restrictive immigration laws in rich countries affect the social reproduction of children in immigrant sending countries. In this case, where the majority of Mexican immigrants are undocumented, laws about immigration status create a form of “imported colonialism” (Ngai, 2004). From the perspective of world systems theory, the essence of a colonial relationship is a situation where the core nation (the United States) exploits the peripheral nation (Mexico). The findings of our study highlight how classifying Mexican immigrants as undocumented creates an intergenerational colonial relationship. Most Mexican immigrants come to the United States to work when they reach late adolescence or adulthood. By classifying the great majority of these immigrants as undocumented, US laws limit Mexican immigrant's ability to bring their families with them—especially their children (Gubernskaya and Dreby, 2017:426). In this project, we find that classifying the immigrants as undocumented also makes it impossible for Mexican immigrants to translate their sacrifices into greater educational attainment for their children. At a more macro level, raising (that is, educating) the children in Mexico reduces expenses of the US state by transferring the cost of eductating them to the Mexican state. It also allows employers to pay immigrants less because the cost of living is lower in Mexico where many of their children reside (Burawoy, 1976). Classifying Mexican immigrants as undocumented creates a binational intergenerational reproduction of unskilled labor. We find that only documented Mexican immigrant parents are able to convert their efforts into greater attainment for their children and a chance for them to *sobre salir* (climb the social ladder). Thus, our findings indicate that US laws about immigration status have a devastating effect—more than two years of school—on the educational attainment of Mexican children left behind by their undocumented or mixed-status immigrant parents.

We also find that it is necessary for both parents to be documented for children's education to rise. Mixed-status parents where only one is documented is not enough. Future research should carefully analyze differences between having both parents documented and mixed-status parents. We tested for differences between these types of families because Abrego (2014) and Yoshikawa (2011) argue that undocumented status has profound effects on many parts of life. We reasoned that if one of the two parents is undocumented, the negative consequences of undocumented status largely remain. These include not only low wages, but also the stress, fear and uncertainty that come from clandestine border crossing and living in the shadows. It is also likely that when the spouse of a documented parent is a temporary immigrant or a nonimmigrant, the effect on the children is similar to when the spouse is undocumented. This follows because if the spouse joins their documented partner, it is likely to be in an undocumented status for many years to come (Gubernskaya and Dreby, 2017).

Our findings also suggest that the benefits of having both parents documented apply to nonimmigrant boys and girls, who earn about two additional years of education. We also find that, conditional on migrating as a teenager, boys earn almost five additional years of education from having both parents documented. The one group of children identified here that do not benefit from having both of their parents documented is girls that migrate as teenagers. It is striking how much more teenage immigrant boys than girls benefit from having two parents documented. We hypothesized the direction of this interaction based on predictions from the logic of the neoclassical economic model. The model suggests that boys with documented parents would benefit more than similar girls from additional education in the United States. This follows because relatively more boys than girls aspire to be breadwinners and because

documentation increases the returns to education more for boys than girls (Hall et al., 2010). Nevertheless, the sex difference we observe is so large that it is likely that other factors are also involved. There is also evidence that teenage Mexican girls have difficulty adapting to life in the United States, that their parents are overly protective, and that they perform extensive amounts of domestic labor (Donato et al., 2006; París Pombo, 2010; Parreñas, 2005; Valenzuela, 1999). Continuing research in this area will be important to understand why teenage immigrant girls do not benefit from having both parents documented to the same extent as boys.

5.2. Policy implications

Our findings suggest that legal changes that would make a larger proportion of Mexican immigrants documented, especially if they simultaneously made it easier for documented immigrants to sponsor their spouse, would improve the educational attainment of children left behind in Mexico. Of course, current US-immigration laws bar the vast majority of Mexican immigrants from legal residency and citizenship. In these data, only two percent of the children had any parent documented even though 28 percent of the children had at least one parent migrate to the United States. Many of the documented parents owe their status to the IRCA, a one-time program that regularized about two million Mexican immigrants in the mid-1990s (Massey et al., 2002). Very few Mexican immigrants have gained residency through the omnibus National Immigration Act before or after the IRCA. Even children who are lucky enough to have a documented parent typically live in mixed-status families where only one parent has documents. Current US-immigration policies make Mexican immigrants undocumented (Johnson and Trujillo, 2011) and undermine family unity, keeping families separated with "lengthy visa backlogs and processing delays, visa restrictions, biased assumptions about family structure, bans on reentry, and separations due to enforcement practices (Gubernskaya and Dreby, 2017:426)." This study suggests that policy changes that would regularize the status of more Mexican immigrants would likely result in greater educational attainment for their children growing up without them in Mexico. We believe that changes to US immigration policy should adopt this goal along with others that emphasize the principles of human rights and family unity for immigrants and their families.

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